UNIVERSITY OF WESTMINSTER

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University of Westminster
University Research Ethics Committee

Application for Research Ethics Consideration*

PART A

Section 1 – PROJECT AND APPLICANT DETAILS

1.1 Project Title: Enhancing Deep Learning using empathy and creativity in serious games role-play simulations.

1.2 Applicant Details

Name:	**University Email Address:**
Contact Address:	**Telephone Number:**
Faculty: Science and Technology	

Please check the relevant box:

Undergraduate ☐ **Postgraduate** ☐ **MPhil/PhD Student** ☒ **Staff** ☐

I confirm I have read the *University's Code of Practice Governing the Ethical Conduct of Research*	**YES** ☒ **NO** ☐

1.3 Supervisor/Dean of Faculty/Faculty Research Director details

Please note that all applicants with a supervisor(s) must ensure that the supervisor signs the declaration at the bottom of this page if completing Part A only or in **Section 10.3** if completing Part B

All **staff** must ensure that their Dean of Faculty, or Faculty Research Director (or nominee), as appropriate, signs the declaration at the bottom of this page if completing Part A only or in **Section 10.3** if completing Part B

Name:	**University Email Address:**
Faculty: Science and Technology	**Telephone Number:**

NOW PLEASE COMPLETE THE REMAINDER OF PART A **(* Part A is a self-assessment form used to ascertain whether you have ethical implications in your work. Part A is not an Application for Consideration by University Research Ethics Committee (UREC) unless specified when submitting. Part B is the Application for Ethical Approval and when submitting, it should have a Cover Sheet and Part A attached in all cases).**

PART A (Continued)

Section 2 – Project Details

2.1 Please provide a description of the background with references to relevant literature (250 words maximum):

There is a shift in education towards policies that promote deeper learning (Fullan and Langworthy, 2013). Serious games are considered to be effective new learning technologies allows the design and development of educational applications for advancing learning. Serious games are digital interactive games that are widely used in the field of education and are designed to have an educational impact on learners aiming to meet specific educational goals (Gee, 2003; Van Eck, 2006; Bellotti et al., 2013; Devlin-Scherer and Sardone, 2010). This research project suggests a theoretical framework that adapts Bloom's educational model for Mastery Learning (1971) for serious games. The framework incorporates empathy and creativity to engage and motivate learners in achieving initially surface learning and then progressing them to more synthetic thinking through creative processes aiming in achieving deeper learning. Empathy is highly valued by educators (Jarvis, 2012). In serious games, empathy is identified to be a design element with great potential to engage learners (Belman and Flanagan, 2009). Creativity is recognised for its huge educational benefits in terms of inspiring learners in transforming and constructing their own learning in a creative way (Agogué, Levillain and Hooge, 2015) and it's considered one of the main ingredients when aiming to achieve deeper learning. The serious game that is developed for this project has the form of role-play simulation and it is designed based on an instructional case related to raising awareness on the issue of domestic violence and abuse.

2.2. Please provide a brief description and the aims of your study (250 words maximum):

This pedagogic research study aims to investigate whether the contribution of empathy and creativity in serious games can support learners effectively in achieving deeper learning. In other words, whether learners can become empathetic while playing the serious game and then get involved in creative activities, would lead them in achieving deeper learning. Already the use of empathy in serious games has been proven to engage learners with the learning content. In this study the aim is to explore whether empathy not only contributes to learners' engagement but also contributes to better learning achievement as well as together with creativity in serious games can contribute in deeper learning. To answer the research question, a number of hypotheses are defined and are going to be tested and validated.

2.3. Please outline the design and methodology of your study (include details of the selection and recruitment of participants (if any) and details of any invasive (e.g. blood samples, inhalation/ingestion of food and/or non-food products (in abnormally higher or lower levels than normal or a different form), or intrusive (e.g. questionnaires, focus groups, interviews, etc.) procedures [attach extra information as necessary] (400 words maximum in total):

This is pedagogic research study based on an experimental design. The proposed method of selection and recruitment will invite approximately 40 participants targeting university students and/or young adults. The number 40 for participants is expected to give adequate data for analysing and extracting valid results. The selection will be random and participants will be assigned in two groups: the experimental and the control group. The experimental group will play the serious game that is developed for the purpose of the research study and will be tested compared to the control group that will have access to the same information using slide presentation. The two groups will be compared as for their learning effectiveness. Specifically, the experimental group will play the serious game in the form of role-play simulation. The scenario presents incidents of abusive behaviour and involves the learner to learn about the issue of domestic violence and abuse.

Data will be collected while playing the game using variables. Variables will hold values for the score, which corresponds to the level of learning, values for the emotional state of the character, and values for the level of empathy of the learner while playing the serious game.

Additional data will be also collected with questionnaires related to the participants such as demographic data, users' experience, and empathy scale questionnaires to give an indication about the level of empathy as a personality trait of the participant.

There is a consideration about the possibility of a participant to get upset while playing the serious game in case this bring them unfortunate memories of past experiences. Measures taken to confront this situation include (1) an introduction sheet that will be given to the participant prior the study that informs participants about the subject and the nature of the game that can be taken away with them, (2) the procedures of the study will be explained to the participants so they will know what to expect, (3) participants will be prompted to give their written consent prior participating to the study showing their willingness to participate (4) participants will be told that if for any reason and at any time during the study they wish to withdraw and not continue participating, this is absolutely fine and they can withdraw without any excuse. Other measures that will be taken on the day of the study involve the intervention of university services for mental health first aiders that will be informed in advance in order to be alerted and called in case of an emergency (University of Westminster safeguarding team email).

2.4. Timescales

Start Date (DD/MM/YY): 23/07/2018

Estimated duration of work: 5 days

Section 3 - RISK OF HARM

NOTE 1: Where indicated below applicants should check if the research will require ethical approval from a National Research Ethics Committee via the Integrated Research Application System (IRAS) - nres.queries@nhs.net.- http://www.hra-decisiontools.org.uk/ethics/
NOTE 2: The University of Westminster holds a Human Tissue Authority Licence – This licence is specifically for tissue stored at 115 New Cavendish Street in accordance with the terms of the licence – Advice must be obtained from the University Human Tissue Authority Officer

RISK OF HARM (to self, colleagues, participants, environment or animals)		Yes	No	N/A
1	Will any pain or more than mild discomfort result from the study?	☐	☒	☐
2	Could the study induce any psychological stress or anxiety or cause harm or negative consequences beyond the risks encountered in normal life?	☐	☒	☐
3	Will the study involve prolonged or repetitive physical or psychological testing of human participants that may put someone at risk, e.g. use of treadmill?	☐	☒	☐
4	Will the study involve raising sensitive topics (e.g. sexual activity, drug use, revelation of medical history, bereavement, illegal activities, etc.)?	☐	☒	☐
5	Does your work involve any "relevant material" containing human cells (e.g. blood, urine, saliva, body tissues but NOT established cell-lines) from living or deceased persons (Such work must take account of the Human Tissue Act)? – See Note 1 and 2 above.	☐	☒	☐
6	Will DNA samples be taken from human participants (Such work must take account of the Human Tissue Act)? – See Note 1 and 2 above.	☐	☒	☐
7	Does your study raise any issues of personal safety for you or other researchers or participants involved in the project (Especially relevant if taking place outside working hours or off University premises)?	☐	☒	☐
8	Does your study involve deliberately misleading the participants (e.g. deception, covert observation)?	☐	☒	☐
9	Does your work involve administration of a food or non-food substance of a different type from or in abnormally higher or lower amounts than normal or one that is known to cause allergic reaction(s) or potential psychological stress?	☐	☒	☐
10	Does your study involve issues relating to personal and/or sensitive data?	☐	☒	☐
PARTICIPANTS (and/or their records/associated data) Does your work involve any of the following:		**Yes**	**No**	**N/A**
11	Human participants in a health and/or social care setting (e.g. patients, those attending day centres, community care, rehabilitation centres, etc., including in the NHS, other public, private and/or voluntary sectors)? – See Note 1 above.	☐	☒	☐
12	Human participants who may be deemed vulnerable (e.g. children, people in poverty and/or with physiological or psychological impairments, persons attending rehabilitation centres, persons in easily identifiable positions that could be subject to victimisation, etc.)?	☐	☒	☐
13	Expectant or new mothers?	☐	☒	☐
14	Refugees/Asylum seekers?	☐	☒	☐
15	Minors (under the age of 18 years old)?	☐	☒	☐
16	Participants in custody (e.g. prisoners or arrestees)? – See Note 1 above.	☐	☒	☐
17	Participants with impaired mental capacity (e.g. severe mental illness, brain damage, sectioned under Mental Health Act, lowered or reduced sense of consciousness)? – See Note 1 above.	☐	☒	☐
18	Animals (or animal tissue).	☐	☒	☐
INFORMATION TO PARTICIPANTS		**Yes**	**No**	**N/A**
19	Will you provide participants with a Participant Information Sheet prior to obtaining informed consent which can be taken away by the participant?	☒	☐	☐
20	Will you describe the procedures to participants in advance, so that they are informed about what to expect?	☒	☐	☐
21	Will you obtain informed consent for participation (normally written)? OR in the case of using personal data previously acquired was consent given for the reuse of the data for other research purposes?	☒	☐	☐
22	Will you tell participants that they may withdraw from the research at any time and for any reason without any impact on their care, service provision etc.?	☒	☐	☐
23	Will you give participants the option of omitting questions they do not want to answer?	☒	☐	☐
24	Will you tell participants that their data will be treated as confidential and that, if published, it will not be identifiable as theirs?	☒	☐	☐
25	Will you offer feedback to participants at the end of their participation, upon request (e.g. give them a brief explanation of the study and its outcomes)?	☒	☐	☐
26	Has external funding or collaboration been applied for/received, which requires institutional ethical consideration or approval?	☐	☐	☒

Useful links:

- http://www.screc.org.uk/ - Social Care Research Ethics Committee
- http://www.hra-decisiontools.org.uk/ethics/ - Human Research Authority decision tool to identify if research needs National Research Ethics Committee approval
- http://www.nres.nhs.uk/applications/guidance/governance-and-directives/?entryid62=131341 – Governance Arrangements for Research Ethics Committees
- http://www.nres.nhs.uk/EasySiteWeb/GatewayLink.aspx?alId=134016 - NRES algorithm "Does my project require review by a Research Ethics Committee"?
- http://www.hta.gov.uk/policiesandcodesofpractice/codesofpractice.cfm - Human Tissue Authority Code of Practice
- http://www.hta.gov.uk – Human Tissue Authority website
- http://www.rsclearn.mrc.ac.uk/MRC_HumanTissueAct/player.html - Medical Research Council online training course for Human Tissue Act.

What to do next:

- **If you have answered NO to questions 1-18 (inclusive) and YES to questions 19-25 (inclusive)**, you do not need to complete the Full Research Ethics Approval Form (Part B). Please keep this form for your records, and do not submit to UREC unless you require ethical consideration of your study, regardless of ethical implications, by an external body (question 26 has been answered YES). *Some Faculties require you lodge a copy of Part A (or a local version of this) with the Faculty Registry/Office, please check with your Faculty Research Ethics Advisor/Co-ordinator. A list of Faculty Ethics Advisors is available from the Secretary, UREC: research-ethics@westminster.ac.uk.*
- **If you have answered YES to any of the questions 1-18 (inclusive) or NO to any of the questions 19-25** the Full Research Ethics Approval Form (Part B) MUST be submitted including Cover Sheet, Part A and Part B of the application form plus any required supplementary documents to the Secretary of the University Research Ethics Committee.
- If you are applying for external Ethical Approval, please send a *copy* of the Conditions/Approvals letters to the Secretary (this may include the original ethical application(s)). Where the external ethics committee/body has equal standing or primary jurisdiction, e.g. another University Research Ethics Committee or a National Research Ethics Committee, any approval will normally be received and noted by the University of Westminster Research Ethics Committee and further clearance may not be required. Where the external committee does not have equal or higher standing than the University Committee then the full ethical approval process at the university may still be required.
- All Applications (dated, signed and authorised) and supplementary information or External Approvals should be sent to the Secretary in *electronic format with a version number, document name and date and the Principal Investigator (or Undergraduate/Postgraduate Taught Student) name. On receipt your application will be issued a unique reference number*
- All new Applications should be submitted to the Secretary a minimum of 10 working days in advance of the Committee meeting date (earlier submission is recommended so that applications can be pre-vetted and obvious issues addressed before the application is considered by the Committee).

Contact details:

Secretary; University Research Ethics Committee
Academic Registrar's Department

E: research-ethics@westminster.ac.uk
W: www.wmin.ac.uk/research-ethics

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